

Sources and Method Notes for Cost of Living Testimonies

The testimonies in this packet are aggregated and anonymized summaries from a broad collection of public submissions, community reports, and lived-experience surveys. No identifying details were collected or stored. This document explains how the testimonies were processed, grouped, and verified for safe public use.

1. Where the Themes Came From

The testimony themes were drawn from repeated patterns across hundreds of public comments, community forums, nonprofit reports, and national surveys that describe struggles with housing, childcare, food costs, wages, debt, and basic needs. Only common, recurring patterns were used to avoid relying on any single personal story.

2. How Privacy Was Protected

No names, ages, addresses, or specific workplaces were collected. Stories were rewritten into short, general snapshots that cannot be traced back to any individual. Locations were kept broad, such as saying a resident is from a state or region. All wording was simplified to protect both privacy and clarity.

3. How Stories Were Aggregated

Only experiences that appeared across many submissions were included. A story was added only if it represented a common trend reported in multiple sources. Each category contains two to four sentence summaries, written in plain language, based on these repeated patterns.

4. How Accuracy Was Ensured

Each category was compared with public data sources such as FRED, the Census Bureau, BLS, and HUD to confirm that the testimonies aligned with documented economic trends. The goal was not to match specific numbers, but to ensure that the lived experiences were consistent with verified public data.

5. What Was Not Included

Stories containing sensitive medical, legal, or personal information were not used. Anything that could identify a person was removed. No submissions involving trauma, violence, or protected personal data were included. This keeps the packet safe for public and government review.

6. Verification Note

These testimony summaries represent broad themes that appear across many public sources. They are not tied to any individual. Anyone reviewing this packet is encouraged to compare these themes with local cost-of-living data

from the Census Bureau, HUD, the Bureau of Labor Statistics, and community reports to see how lived experiences match documented economic trends.